Tactix: Tier-C Checker-Timeout Gate Failure

Report to Andrew

25 September 2026

Outcome

The matched AM427 Sweep Tier-C array is terminal but *not* a clean correctness or performance gate. Both arms solved 29/30 with independently checked models or proofs; on the same remaining AES instance, each emitted UNSAT but its native DSR checker exhausted the campaign's 4,800-second budget. The dependent aggregate deliberately failed with a `CORRECTNESS-BUG` resource-failure marker. This is a timeout, not a reported proof rejection, and neither permits an N2 acceptance claim. The detailed evidence is AM434.

Exact evidence

All 60 task records are present and all 30 candidate–parent verdicts and proof sizes match: 15 SAT and 15 UNSAT verdicts per arm. Fifteen SAT models and fourteen UNSAT proofs per arm passed their independent original-CNF checks. On `aes_decry_2_rounds`, the two 238,948,969-byte DSR proofs each reached the 4,800-second checker ceiling after roughly 100-second solves. The benchmark cleaned those proof artifacts, so its equal-size records alone did not prove byte identity. Its 29/30 PAR-2 headline is unscorable as a complete gate; the small apparent paired runtime gain is single-case-sensitive and does not establish N4.

A separate, immutable two-task diagnostic array, `1723443`, now repeats only this original input and both exact solver binary hashes with the frozen no-option DSR/Trestle checkers. It preserves the Tier-C 1,200-second solve cap, eight CPUs and 32 GiB, and extends only the checker allowance to 45,000 seconds. Both provisional solver records again report UNSAT and now show identical full proof SHA-256 values (`6a04b015...db4a62`; full hash in AM434). That is certificate identity, *not* verification: both checker verdicts remain pending. The diagnostic uses anonymous node-local scratch and has not changed the frozen Tier-C run.

Next actions and separate blockers

Inspect each terminal checker stage and original-CNF result from array `1723443`. If the proof verifies, preserve the Tier-C 4,800-second failure as a resource-limit result and design a matched, independently checked successor gate; if it rejects or exhausts 45,000 seconds, diagnose the exact stage before further performance work. The current-source full Debug job `1723391` is running, while affected Claude-owned fuzz remains separate. H2's canonical no-option DSR rejection is an independent general N2 blocker. N1–N4, cumulative Rank/B+C/WV coverage, and the post-goal Tier-D comparison remain open. The learning-readiness report's three major policy refactors are unchanged.